



CALEB VALDEZ at his southwest Colorado ranch. “It’s affecting us directly,” Valdez says of global warming.

A blitz against landmark plastics state law

By SUSANNE RUST

California’s embattled single-use plastics law is still alive — despite multiple lawsuits, political pressure and widespread ad campaigns to destroy it.

While leaders in the packaging industry wait to see how the courts respond to legal challenges against the Plastic Pollution Prevention and Packaging Producer Responsibility Act, or state Senate Bill 54, several have decided to tackle the law on the political front, lobbying legislators and filling inboxes and mailboxes with messages and mailers urging Californians to turn against the law.

Leading the blitz is a seven-month-old coalition, Californians for Affordable Packaging. The only stated goal on the organization’s website is to “pause and replace” the act. The law is intended to reduce single-use plastics in the state and make all packaging material and single-use food service items recyclable or compostable by 2032.

It is unclear who is behind the organization, although officials from the Dairy Institute of California, the California League of Food Producers and the California Restaurant Assn., among others, sit on its board.

“Californians agree on the goal: less plastic pollution and a recycling system that works. The question is whether SB 54, as written, can deliver it,” said William Valentine, a spokesman for the packaging coalition.

In June, the same month the organization registered as a lobbying firm with the state, it published an econo-

Ranchers take stand over climate change

Coloradans seek accountability from Big Oil

By IAN JAMES

In the Rocky Mountains, years of extreme heat and drought have baked the landscape, drying up streams that feed the Colorado River and desiccating pastures where cattle graze.

The unrelenting dryness has brought hardship upon cattle ranchers, who say their livelihoods increasingly are under threat.

As the U.S. Supreme Court considers a case in

which major oil companies are being sued for the effects of global warming, a group of Colorado ranchers is voicing support for the idea that the fossil fuel industry should be held to account.

“It’s affecting us directly,” rancher Caleb Valdez said. “I hope the lawsuit holds the largest contributors accountable for the consequences.”

The Supreme Court case

stems from a lawsuit the city and county of Boulder, Colo., filed against Suncor Energy and Exxon Mobil in 2018. It argues that the oil companies have for decades concealed and misrepresented the dangers of fossil fuels and that they should help pay the rising costs of more intense wildfires, drought and heat waves, among other problems linked to cli-

[See Ranchers, A8]



GILES CLARKE Getty Images

A PARAMILITARY group plundered artifacts from Sudan’s National Museum.

War erases Sudan’s cultural legacy

By NABIH BULOS

KHARTOUM, Sudan — The ancient statues of the deities Heket and Beset, too heavy to move, were used for target practice. The 4,000-year-old skeletal remains from the bio-archaeology lab? Scattered or scorched. The gold vault lies ransacked, the storage rooms firebombed.

Walk through the grounds of the Sudan National Museum and the reminders of the civil war’s devastating impact on this country’s cultural history seem everywhere.

“It was systematic. They entered the depots and stole everything they could,” said Umaima Abdul-Rahman Al-Sanusi, one of the museum’s curators, as her eyes scanned a shattered display

case. She was referring to the Rapid Support Forces, or RSF, a paramilitary group that controlled the capital — and the museum with it — from April 2023 until government forces dislodged them in March of last year.

When Al-Sanusi first saw the level of destruction in the museum — where she’s been employed around 15 years — she cried. Even now, more

[See Museum, A3]

Becerra pivots on California’s death penalty

He once defended it but says he would extend a moratorium if elected governor.

By NICOLE NIXON

SACRAMENTO — Democrat Xavier Becerra defended the death penalty while serving as California’s attorney general, a punishment his office actively sought in the case of a gunman convicted of an Orange County mass shooting, but as the front-running candidate for governor he has vowed to block executions if elected in November.

Becerra said he will extend the blanket reprieve for all death row inmates that Gov. Gavin Newsom enacted by executive order in 2019, saying he supported “moving our state away from a costly, flawed system that disproportionately impacts Black and brown communities and too often gets it wrong.”

Those comments have reassured anti-death penalty advocates wary of Becerra, who has stated throughout his career that capital punishment should be an option for victims seeking justice. He reiterated that stance just a

decade ago during his confirmation hearing for attorney general, though he also expressed concerns about the unjust application of the punishment.

“I support the death penalty, but I hate the way it’s being executed,” Becerra told state lawmakers in 2017.

“If you commit some heinous crime where you have taken the life of someone else, and you knew that there was a death penalty in place in that place where you committed that crime, then you should face the punishment for what you’ve done,” he explained. “It doesn’t give me pleasure to say that, but I simply do believe there’s a simple justice in that.”

Becerra’s challenger in the Nov. 3 election, former Fox News commentator Steve Hilton, opposes the death penalty but said he would rescind Newsom’s moratorium because it defies the will of voters.

Becerra has said he is concerned by how death sentences historically have been applied, including a highly disproportionate number of condemned inmates who are Black or Latino men and cases in which they later have been exonerated of crimes.

He repeated similar positions last year during a gut-

[See Becerra, A5]

Record summer box office boosts hope for the year

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

In the months leading up to summer, Paul Gunsky installed new reclining seats and immersive sound systems at his Bay Area Cine-Lux Theatres chain in hopes that moviegoers would return in droves.

And they did. Young people flocked to his showings of “Obsession” as the Gen Z horror film gained momentum throughout the summer, while nostalgic millennials came to watch “The Devil Wears Prada 2,” propelling business for his chain of eight theaters with 62 screens above that of last year.

Driven by billion-dollar-plus blockbusters, the popularity of Imax and other enhanced formats, and a diverse lineup of films, this summer’s box office has given theater owners such as Gunsky a much-needed shot

in the arm and boosted optimism for the rest of the year.

The season’s heaviest lifting came from Sony Pictures’ “Spider-Man: Brand New Day” (\$2.4 billion in global box office), Christopher Nolan’s “The Odyssey” (\$1.6 billion) and Walt Disney Co. and Pixar’s “Toy Story 5” (\$1.1 billion), though a wide-ranging crop of quality movies helped push the summer over the edge.

For the full summer — which the industry counts from the first Friday in May through Labor Day — theatrical revenue in the U.S. and Canada is expected to reach \$4.76 billion, marking the highest summer ever, not adjusted for inflation, according to Rentrak.

That’s welcome news for the major Hollywood studios, which still count theatrical revenue as a key source of business during a tumultuous time for the industry.

[See Movies, A12]



Pixar/Disney

“TOY STORY 5” and other hits helped push domestic box-office revenue to \$4.76 billion this summer.

Arson suspect says he fought capitalism

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

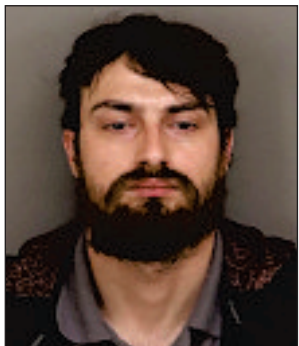
A massive 1.2-million-square-foot warehouse in Ontario was still on fire when videos began to appear on social media platforms.

Holding a phone camera with one hand and a lighter in the other, Chamel Abdulkarim is heard on the video listing off complaints about not being paid enough to get by. Authorities allege

he methodically set fire to a Kimberly-Clark paper goods warehouse April 7, causing hundreds of millions of dollars’ worth of losses.

“You know, if you’re not going to pay us enough to f— live or to afford to live, at least pay us enough not to do this,” he is heard saying in a video on his Instagram page as another packet of toilet paper is set aflame. “All you had to do is pay us enough to live.”

And with that, a spectacular arson fire that lev-



Ontario Police Department

CHAMEL Abdulkarim is accused in Ontario arson.

eled the complex took on a political dimension. Abdulkarim has since been charged in the fire, and authorities intend to use his words and images against him. They argue his motive was clear: Harm the company he worked for. In the process, prosecutors have argued in court, he put the lives of co-workers and firefighters at risk.

The case is shaping up to be a legal — and moral — showdown over whether

[See Abdulkarim, A6]

A clouded local Labor Day

Union workers at a Wilmington rally express worries about automation and affordability. CALIFORNIA, B1

The ugly side of selling cute stuff

After its sales took off on live TikTok, JapanLA store was targeted by trolls. BUSINESS, A10

Weather
Sunny spells; hot.
L.A. Basin: 94/76. B6

McVay helps run head coach route

Five former Rams assistants who worked with coach are now in the leadership position themselves. SPORTS, B10

60th anniversary of ‘Star Trek’

Franchise stars and fans share a hopeful vision. ENTERTAINMENT, E1



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